

Paper Decoder

September 2026 compilation

6 days · 18 stories

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1. India launches commercial production of bio-based biodegradable Polylactic Acid plastic

The initiative under the Biotechnology for Economy, Environment and Employment (BioE3) framework will establish a pilot facility in Uttar Pradesh to develop advanced bioplastics.

What happened	The government launched the commercial use of bio-based biodegradable Polylactic Acid (PLA) plastic under the Biotechnology for Economy, Environment and Employment (BioE3) framework.
Why UPSC cares	This launch under the BioE3 (Biotechnology for Economy, Environment and Employment) framework is crucial for studying sustainable manufacturing and India's efforts to reduce plastic pollution through green alternatives.
Syllabus	GS3 Environment: Conservation, environmental pollution and degradation
Chapter	Environment: Pollution: Types, Sources & Control

Read it for

1. Understand the science of Polylactic Acid (PLA) as a biodegradable polymer.
2. Examine the goals of the Biotechnology for Economy, Environment and Employment (BioE3) framework.
3. Analyze the growth and potential of India's bioeconomy sector.

Key terms

Polylactic Acid (PLA)

A biodegradable and bioactive thermoplastic aliphatic polyester derived from renewable resources like corn starch or sugarcane.

BioE3 Framework

A government initiative standing for Biotechnology for Economy, Environment and Employment, aimed at fostering high-performance biomanufacturing.

Bioeconomy

An economic model based on the utilization of biological resources, biotechnology, and bioprocesses to produce goods, services, and energy.

Biodegradable Plastic

Plastics that can be decomposed by the action of living organisms, usually microbes, into water, carbon dioxide, and biomass under specific conditions.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding Polylactic Acid (PLA):

1. It is a bio-based polymer typically synthesized from renewable agricultural resources like sugarcane or corn starch.
2. All PLA-based plastics degrade rapidly in standard backyard home composting bins without requiring industrial composting facilities.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- a. 1 only
- b. 2 only
- c. Both 1 and 2
- d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (a) Statement 1 is correct: Polylactic Acid (PLA) is a biodegradable polyester derived from renewable biomass sources, such as fermented plant starch (usually corn, cassava, sugarcane or sugar beet pulp). Statement 2 is incorrect: Although PLA is biodegradable, it requires specific high-temperature industrial composting conditions (around 58-60 degrees Celsius with controlled humidity and microbes) to degrade efficiently. It does not decompose rapidly in standard backyard home composting environments.

Mains: how it could come

Explain the significance of the Biotechnology for Economy, Environment and Employment (BioE3) framework in driving India's bioeconomy. Discuss the challenges associated with the commercial scaling of biodegradable plastics like Polylactic Acid (PLA). (150 words, 10 marks)

The BioE3 framework aims to transition India towards high-performance biomanufacturing, promoting sustainable alternatives like Polylactic Acid (PLA) to mitigate environmental degradation.

- Significance of BioE3: Fosters high-value biomanufacturing, reduces carbon footprint, integrates industry-academia collaboration, and generates employment.
- Economic Growth: Supports India's rapidly expanding bioeconomy, which grew from 10 billion dollars in 2014 to nearly 195 billion dollars.
- Challenges of PLA Scaling: High cost of production compared to conventional petroleum-based plastics.
- Infrastructure Gaps: Requires specialized industrial composting infrastructure, as PLA does not degrade quickly in normal landfills or oceans.

To successfully scale bioplastics, India must couple production incentives with waste management policies that mandate industrial composting facilities.

Keywords to use: BioE3 framework, Polylactic Acid (PLA), Bioeconomy, Industrial composting, Biomanufacturing

GS2 · International Relations

2. G4 nations push for urgent United Nations Security Council reform

Foreign Ministers of India, Brazil, Germany and Japan met in New York to press for structural expansion of the United Nations Security Council.

What happened	Foreign Ministers of G4 countries met on the sidelines of the United Nations General Assembly in New York to demand urgent reform and expansion of the United Nations Security Council.
Why UPSC cares	The joint call by Group of Four (G4) nations (India, Brazil, Germany, Japan) highlights the urgent need for United Nations Security Council (UNSC) reforms, a key topic for Mains on global governance.
Syllabus	GS2 International Relations: Bilateral, regional and global groupings and agreements involving India and affecting India's interests.
Chapter	Polity: India's External Relations

Read it for

1. Understand the composition and core objectives of the G4 grouping.
2. Examine the structural flaws of the United Nations Security Council.
3. Analyze the role of the Intergovernmental Negotiations framework.

Key terms

G4 Nations

A coalition comprising India, Brazil, Germany and Japan that support each other's bids for permanent seats on the United Nations Security Council.

United Nations Security Council

The principal crisis management body of the United Nations tasked with maintaining international peace and security.

Inter-governmental Negotiations

A framework established under the United Nations General Assembly to discuss reforms of the United Nations Security Council.

Veto Power

The special voting power held by the five permanent members of the United Nations Security Council to block any substantive resolution.

Mains: how it could come

Analyze the hurdles in reforming the United Nations Security Council and discuss India's strategic rationale for seeking a permanent seat in the Council. (150 words, 10 marks)

The United Nations Security Council reflects the geopolitical realities of 1945, making its structure outdated and unrepresentative of contemporary global power dynamics.

- Geopolitical resistance from existing permanent members who are reluctant to dilute their veto powers or share global authority.
- Regional rivalries where neighboring countries oppose each other's inclusion, such as the Coffee Club opposing the G4 bids.
- India's credentials as the world's largest democracy, a major contributor to United Nations peacekeeping missions, and an emerging economic powerhouse.
- The lack of representation from Africa and Latin America, weakening the moral legitimacy and efficacy of multilateral decisions.

India must build broader coalitions with developing nations and leverage multilateral platforms to push for text-based negotiations in the United Nations General Assembly.

Keywords to use: Multilateralism, Veto Power, Inter-governmental Negotiations, Coffee Club, Equitable Representation

GS3 · Economy

3. Government cuts basic customs duty on crude edible oils to cool prices

The reduction in import duties on crude sunflower, soybean and palm oils aims to provide relief to consumers facing high inflation.

What happened	The Government reduced the Basic Customs Duty on crude sunflower, soybean and palm oils to moderate rising domestic food prices.
Why UPSC cares	The reduction in Basic Customs Duty (BCD) on crude edible oils is a key fiscal measure to control domestic inflation, illustrating the trade-offs between consumer relief and domestic oilseed production incentives.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: Inclusive growth and issues arising from it
Chapter	Economy: External Sector of India

Read it for

1. Understand how import duty adjustments act as a fiscal tool to manage domestic inflation.
2. Examine the rationale behind maintaining a duty differential between crude and refined oils.
3. Analyze the impact of global price trends on domestic food security and consumer welfare.

Key terms

Basic Customs Duty

It is a tax levied on goods imported into India, calculated as a percentage of the value of the goods. It serves as a tool for revenue generation and domestic industry protection.

Import Duty Differential

The gap between the duty rates applied on crude raw materials and finished refined products. Maintaining this gap protects domestic refining industries and encourages value addition.

Headline Inflation

The total inflation within an economy, including commodities such as food and energy prices, which tend to be much more volatile and prone to sudden spikes.

Landed Cost

The total cost of a product once it has arrived at the buyer's door, including the purchase price, freight, insurance, and all applicable customs duties and taxes.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding import duties and domestic price management in India:

1. Reducing the Basic Customs Duty on raw material imports lowers the landed cost for domestic processing industries.
2. Maintaining an import duty differential between crude and refined oils is primarily aimed at discouraging domestic value addition.
3. International commodity price surges can directly transmit into domestic food inflation if trade policy buffers are not utilized.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- a. 1 and 2 only
- b. 2 and 3 only
- c. 1 and 3 only
- d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (c) Reducing import duties lowers the landed cost of raw materials, helping processors pass benefits to consumers. Duty differentials are maintained to protect domestic refiners and encourage domestic processing rather than discouraging it. Unchecked international spikes easily transmit to local markets, making duty cuts a necessary buffer.

Mains: how it could come

Analyze the structural challenges facing India's edible oil sector and discuss the role of trade policy measures, such as customs duty adjustments, in managing domestic food inflation. (150 words, 10 marks)

India imports a significant portion of its edible oil requirements, making domestic prices vulnerable to international market shocks and necessitating timely fiscal interventions.

- High import dependency exposes the domestic market to global price volatility, supply chain disruptions, and currency fluctuations.
- Tariff adjustments like reducing Basic Customs Duty act as immediate shock absorbers to lower landed costs and contain food inflation.
- Maintaining a duty differential between crude and refined oils protects domestic refining capacity and prevents dumping of finished goods.
- Long-term solutions require boosting domestic oilseed productivity through missions like the National Mission on Edible Oils.

A balanced approach combining short-term tariff rationalization with long-term domestic production enhancement is essential for sustainable edible oil security.

Keywords to use: Import dependency, Basic Customs Duty, Food inflation, Duty differential, Oilseed productivity

1. Centre extends AFSPA in parts of Manipur, Nagaland and Arunachal

The Ministry of Home Affairs has extended the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act, 1958, across designated disturbed areas in three north-eastern states for six months.

What happened	The Ministry of Home Affairs extended AFSPA for six months from 1 October in parts of Manipur, Nagaland, and Arunachal Pradesh.
Why UPSC cares	This extension of the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act (AFSPA) highlights ongoing security challenges in the Northeast. It is crucial for understanding internal security and federal relations under General Studies Paper 3.
Syllabus	GS3 Internal Security: Linkages between development and spread of extremism, role of external state and non-state actors in creating challenges to internal security.
Chapter	Polity: National Integration: Key Facts & Functions

Read it for

1. Statutory procedure for declaring an area as disturbed under Section 3 of AFSPA.
2. Special operational powers and legal protections conferred on armed forces personnel.
3. Security and human rights debates surrounding the phased withdrawal of AFSPA in the Northeast.

Key terms

Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act, 1958 (AFSPA)

A Parliamentary enactment that grants special powers to the armed forces to maintain public order in designated disturbed areas.

Disturbed Area

An area notified under Section 3 of AFSPA where the use of armed forces in aid of civil power is deemed necessary due to civil unrest or insurgency.

Prior Sanction

A statutory requirement under Section 6 of AFSPA where legal proceedings against military personnel acting under the law require prior central approval.

Aid to Civil Power

The deployment of military or central paramilitary forces to support civilian administration and state police in quelling unrest and restoring public order.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act, 1958 (AFSPA), consider the following statements:

1. An area can be declared as a 'disturbed area' either by the Central Government or by the Governor of the concerned State.
2. Armed forces personnel operating in a disturbed area have the legal authority to set up summary courts to prosecute arrested persons.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- a. 1 only
- b. 2 only
- c. Both 1 and 2
- d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (a) Statement 1 is correct: Under Section 3 of AFSPA, the Central Government, the Governor of the State, or the Administrator of the Union Territory can declare the whole or any part of a State or Union Territory as a disturbed area. Statement 2 is incorrect: AFSPA gives armed forces personnel powers of search, seizure, and arrest without warrant, but Section 5 explicitly mandates that any person arrested must be handed over to the nearest police station with the least possible delay. The armed forces have no power to set up courts or try civilians.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the operational necessity and human rights concerns associated with the enforcement of the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act, 1958 in the North-Eastern region. (150 words, 10 marks)

The Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act, 1958 grants sweeping powers to military personnel deployed in designated disturbed areas to assist civil administration in counter-insurgency operations.

- Operational necessity: Porous international borders, complex ethnic fault lines, and heavily armed insurgent groups require robust deterrence and specialized military capabilities beyond the capacity of local police.
- Human rights and legal concerns: Wide powers under Section 4, including use of lethal force and warrantless arrests, coupled with Section 6 immunity requiring Central sanction for prosecution, create accountability gaps.
- Democratic deficit: Prolonged reliance on extraordinary military laws normalizes an emergency regime and risks alienating local populations, undermining civic integration.
- Institutional reviews: The Justice Jeevan Reddy Committee recommended repealing AFSPA and incorporating necessary security provisions into ordinary criminal law to avoid stigmatization.

A progressive phased withdrawal, continuous capacity enhancement of state police forces, and adherence to the Supreme Court guidelines in the Naga People's Movement for Human Rights case are vital.

Keywords to use: disturbed areas, Section 6 immunity, Justice Jeevan Reddy Committee, police modernization, counter-insurgency

GS3 · Environment

2. Nepal PM proposes Himalayan climate resilience mechanism with India and China

Nepal Prime Minister Balendra Shah proposed a joint mechanism to share satellite data and early-warning information following devastating flash floods in the region.

What happened	Nepal proposed a trilateral Himalayan Climate Resilience Mechanism with India and China at the 81st United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) session following devastating flash floods that killed 1,452 people.
Why UPSC cares	The proposed Himalayan Climate Resilience Mechanism is vital for regional ecological security. It is highly relevant for transboundary climate cooperation and disaster management under General Studies Paper 3.
Syllabus	GS3 Environment: Environmental pollution and degradation, disaster and disaster management.
Chapter	Environment: Consequences of a Warming World

Read it for

1. Understand the impact of climate change on the fragile Himalayan ecosystem, specifically focusing on permafrost melting and ice-rock avalanches.
2. Examine the role of transboundary cooperation in disaster management and early warning systems among India, Nepal and China.
3. Analyze the significance of multilateral platforms like the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) in addressing regional climate vulnerabilities.

Key terms

Permafrost

Ground that remains completely frozen at or below zero degrees Celsius for at least two consecutive years, commonly found in high-latitude or high-altitude regions.

Glacial Lake Outburst Flood (GLOF)

A sudden release of water from a lake fed by glacier melt, often triggered by avalanches, landslides or the collapse of the natural dam holding the water.

Cascading Disasters

An extreme event where one primary hazard triggers a sequence of secondary hazards, leading to compounded impacts that are harder to manage.

Climate Resilience

The capacity of social, economic and environmental systems to cope with a hazardous event, trend or disturbance by responding or reorganising in ways that maintain their essential function.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to permafrost, consider the following statements:

1. It is defined as ground that remains completely frozen at or below zero degrees Celsius for at least two consecutive years.
2. The thawing of permafrost can release greenhouse gases like methane and carbon dioxide, creating a positive feedback loop in global warming.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- a. 1 only
- b. 2 only
- c. Both 1 and 2
- d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct. Permafrost is defined as ground (soil, rock, and organic material) that remains at or below zero degrees Celsius for at least two consecutive years. Statement 2 is correct. As permafrost thaws, organic matter trapped in the ice begins to decay, releasing large amounts of methane and carbon dioxide, which are potent greenhouse gases. This amplifies global warming, creating a positive feedback loop.

Mains: how it could come

The fragile ecosystem of the Hindu Kush Himalayan region is increasingly threatened by cascading disasters driven by climate change. In this context, evaluate the ecological and geopolitical challenges in establishing a transboundary disaster resilience mechanism among India, Nepal, and China. (150 words, 10 marks)

The Hindu Kush Himalayan region is highly vulnerable to warming, leading to accelerated glacial melt, permafrost degradation, and frequent transboundary disasters like flash floods.

- **Ecological Vulnerability:** High altitude warming causes ice-rock avalanches, landslides, and Glacial Lake Outburst Floods (GLOFs) that cascade downstream across national borders.
- **Geopolitical Friction:** Strategic mistrust and border disputes between India and China hamper seamless satellite data sharing, joint technical research, and real-time early warning coordination.
- **Institutional Gaps:** Existing bilateral frameworks are fragmented and lack a unified, legally binding trilateral mechanism to manage shared river basins and mountain ecosystems.
- **Socio-Economic Impact:** Downstream populations in Nepal and India suffer immense loss of lives, livelihoods, and critical infrastructure due to uncoordinated disaster responses.

Establishing a science-first, non-political platform under regional bodies or United Nations guidance can foster trust, enabling collaborative data sharing and climate-resilient infrastructure development.

Keywords to use: Hindu Kush Himalaya, Glacial Lake Outburst Flood (GLOF), transboundary cooperation, climate resilience, geopolitical mistrust

GS3 · Science and Technology

3. Artificial intelligence could boost long term aggregate labor productivity by 3.8 percent

A new research paper analyzing patent and employment data shows that artificial intelligence technologies can significantly enhance output per worker when complementing skilled labor.

What happened	A study analyzing patent data from 2000 to 2017 in developed economies indicates that Artificial Intelligence (AI) can increase aggregate labor productivity by up to 3.8 percent over the long term.
Why UPSC cares	This International Monetary Fund (IMF) study on Artificial Intelligence (AI) and productivity is key for understanding the economic impact of technology and future of work under General Studies Paper 3.
Syllabus	GS3 Science and Technology: developments and their applications and effects in everyday life.
Chapter	Science & Tech: AI & Emerging Digital Tech

Read it for

1. Impact of Artificial Intelligence (AI) on aggregate labor productivity and economic growth.
2. The complementary relationship between advanced technology and skilled labor force.
3. Role of patent activity as a metric for measuring technological innovation and economic returns.

Key terms

Labor Productivity

The measure of economic output produced per unit of labor input, typically calculated as real gross domestic product per hour worked or per worker.

Capital-Complementing Technology

Technologies that increase the productivity of workers, allowing them to produce more output, rather than replacing them entirely.

Aggregate Output

The total value of all final goods and services produced in an economy over a specific period of time.

Patent Activity

The filing and granting of patents, often used as an indicator of technological innovation and research and development intensity in an economy.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to economic growth and labor productivity, consider the following statements:

1. Labor productivity in an economy is solely determined by the amount of physical capital per worker, and is independent of technological advancements.
2. When new technology complements skilled labor, it typically leads to higher aggregate economic returns compared to when it merely replaces existing tasks.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- a. 1 only
- b. 2 only
- c. Both 1 and 2
- d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is incorrect because labor productivity is heavily influenced by technological progress, human capital, and organizational efficiency, not just physical capital. Statement 2 is correct because technological innovations that complement human skills enhance worker efficiency and generate stronger, sustainable economic growth compared to simple automation that only substitutes labor.

Mains: how it could come

Discuss how Artificial Intelligence (AI) can act as a double-edged sword for developing economies like India. Suggest measures to ensure that AI adoption enhances aggregate labor productivity without exacerbating unemployment and economic inequality. (150 words, 10 marks)

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is a transformative technology capable of boosting aggregate labor productivity, but it also poses significant risks of labor displacement.

- **Productivity Boost:** AI can automate routine tasks, enabling workers to focus on high-value cognitive activities, thereby increasing output per worker.
- **Labor Market Challenges:** Developing nations face the risk of premature de-industrialization and job losses in service sectors like Information Technology (IT) and business process outsourcing.
- **Skill Mismatch:** The benefits of AI may disproportionately accrue to skilled workers, widening the wage gap and increasing economic inequality.
- **Complementarity Approach:** Focusing on AI as a tool to assist and enhance human capabilities rather than completely replacing workers.

India must invest in comprehensive upskilling programs, establish robust regulatory frameworks for ethical AI, and promote labor-complementing AI applications in agriculture and healthcare.

Keywords to use: labor productivity, labor displacement, upskilling, inclusive growth, complementarity

1. Russia backs India for a permanent seat in the UN Security Council

The Russian Foreign Minister has strongly advocated for India and Brazil to get permanent seats in an expanded United Nations Security Council.

What happened	Russia has expressed strong official support for India and Brazil to secure permanent seats in an expanded United Nations Security Council.
Why UPSC cares	Essential for GS2 International Relations. Covers major power alignments on United Nations Security Council reform and India's multilateral diplomacy.
Syllabus	GS2 International Relations: Bilateral, regional and global groupings and agreements involving India and/or affecting India's interests.
Chapter	Polity: India's External Relations

Read it for

1. Understand the composition and current structure of the United Nations Security Council.
2. Examine the arguments for and against reforming the global multilateral governance architecture.
3. Analyze the strategic geopolitical alignments regarding the Global South.

Key terms

United Nations Security Council

One of the principal organs of the United Nations tasked with maintaining international peace and security. It has fifteen members, including five permanent members with veto power.

Veto Power

The special voting power held by the five permanent members of the United Nations Security Council, allowing any one of them to block the adoption of a substantive resolution.

Global South

A term often used to refer to developing and lower-income countries located primarily in Asia, Africa, and Latin America, advocating for greater equity in global affairs.

BRICS

An intergovernmental organization comprising Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa, and newly added members, aimed at fostering economic and geopolitical cooperation.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the United Nations Security Council:

1. It consists of fifteen members in total, out of which ten are non-permanent members elected for two-year terms.
2. All permanent and non-permanent members possess veto power over substantive resolutions.
3. Regional representation in the Security Council is heavily criticized for underrepresenting the Global South.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- a. 1 and 3 only
- b. 2 and 3 only
- c. 1 only
- d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (a) The United Nations Security Council has fifteen members: five permanent and ten non-permanent members elected for two-year terms, making statement 1 correct. Veto power is exclusively held by the five permanent members, making statement 2 incorrect. The current structure does not adequately represent Asia, Africa, and Latin America, leading to calls for reform from the Global South, making statement 3 correct.

Mains: how it could come

Analyze the structural anomalies of the United Nations Security Council and explain why India's inclusion as a permanent member is essential for a credible global governance architecture. (150 words, 10 marks)

The United Nations Security Council, created in nineteen forty-five, reflects the geopolitical realities of the post-World War II era rather than contemporary global demographics.

- Representation deficit: The council excludes entire regions like Africa and Latin America from permanent representation.
- India's credentials: India is the most populous nation, a major global economy, a vibrant democracy, and a leading contributor to United Nations peacekeeping missions.
- Multilateral legitimacy: Without restructuring, the council risks losing its moral authority and effectiveness in addressing twenty-first-century security threats.

India must continue forging strategic coalitions like the G4 and BRICS while building broader consensus among developing nations to push for comprehensive multilateral reforms.

Keywords to use: Multilateralism, Veto Power, Global South, Geopolitical Realities, Institutional Reform

GS3 · Science and Technology

2. India pitches for secure and democratic artificial intelligence at United Nations

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar co-chaired an event on artificial intelligence and maritime security at the United Nations in New York.

What happened

External Affairs Minister Dr S Jaishankar co-chaired an event on artificial intelligence in international peace and security with an emphasis on maritime security at the

	United Nations.
Why UPSC cares	Crucial for GS3 Science and Technology. Connects artificial intelligence governance with international security and maritime domain awareness.
Syllabus	GS3 Science and Technology: Awareness in the fields of IT and Computers
Chapter	Science & Tech: AI & Emerging Digital Tech

Read it for

1. Note the dual nature of artificial intelligence in maritime security, spanning both domain awareness and cyber vulnerabilities.
2. Understand the governance challenges of autonomous maritime systems regarding attribution and accountability.
3. Examine the core principles of the New Delhi Declaration concerning democratic access to artificial intelligence.

Key terms

Maritime Domain Awareness

The effective understanding of anything associated with the maritime domain that could impact security, safety, economy, or environment.

Autonomous Maritime Systems

Vessels or systems operating in water that can make decisions and execute actions without direct human intervention using sensors and algorithms.

United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea

The international agreement that establishes a legal framework for all marine and maritime activities across the globe.

Reconnaissance

Military observation of a region to locate an enemy or ascertain strategic features using advanced technological surveillance tools.

Mains: how it could come

Evaluate the strategic opportunities and security challenges posed by the integration of artificial intelligence into maritime security architectures. (150 words, 10 marks)

The convergence of artificial intelligence with maritime security presents a dual paradigm of enhanced situational awareness alongside complex geopolitical and cybersecurity risks.

- Enhances maritime domain awareness through predictive analytics, advanced reconnaissance, and efficient search and rescue operations.
- Secures critical infrastructure like ports and undersea communication cables against physical and digital disruptions.
- Introduces severe security risks, including autonomous weapon systems, compressed decision-making times, and escalation spirals.
- Complicates legal accountability and attribution, challenging existing frameworks of international law and state responsibility.

Global cooperation based on democratic principles, transparency, and adherence to international maritime law is essential to harness artificial intelligence safely.

Keywords to use: Maritime domain awareness, Autonomous systems, Attribution, Cyber operations, International law

GS3 · Environment & Ecology

3. Bandhavgarh Tiger Reserve hosts five day elephant rejuvenation camp in buffer zone

A five day elephant festival and health rejuvenation camp is underway near Parasi Gate in the Dhamokhar buffer zone of Bandhavgarh Tiger Reserve.

What happened	Bandhavgarh Tiger Reserve organised a five day rejuvenation camp for working elephants near Parasi Gate in its Dhamokhar buffer zone.
Why UPSC cares	Vital for GS3 Environment. Focuses on captive elephant welfare and management practices within protected tiger reserves in India.
Syllabus	GS3 Environment: Conservation, wildlife protection, and biodiversity management.
Chapter	Environment: Saving Species: Conservation in Action

Read it for

1. Role of working elephants in forest management and wildlife protection.
2. Buffer zone management and its importance in reducing human wildlife conflict.
3. Conservation initiatives for Asian elephants and community participation.

Key terms

Asian Elephant

The Asian Elephant (**Elephas maximus**) is listed as Endangered on the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) Red List and included in Schedule I of the Wildlife Protection Act, 1972.

Buffer Zone

An area surrounding a core protected area where regulated human activities, eco-tourism, and conservation awareness programs are permitted.

Project Elephant

A Centrally Sponsored Scheme launched in 1992 to protect wild elephants, their habitats, and migration corridors across India.

Elephant Corridor

A narrow strip of land that connects two larger elephant habitats, allowing free movement of elephant herds and maintaining genetic diversity.

Prelims: how it could come

With reference to the Asian Elephant (*Elephas maximus*), consider the following statements:

- 1. It is listed as Vulnerable on the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) Red List.**
- 2. It is classified under Schedule II of the Wildlife Protection Act, 1972.**

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- a. 1 only
- b. 2 only
- c. Both 1 and 2
- d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is incorrect: The Asian Elephant is listed as Endangered on the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) Red List, not Vulnerable. Statement 2 is incorrect: Asian Elephants are protected under Schedule I of the Wildlife Protection Act, 1972, providing them the highest level of legal protection in India.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the role of buffer zone management and captive elephant care in strengthening wildlife conservation efforts in India. (150 words, 10 marks)

Buffer zones act as transition regions between human settlements and core wildlife habitats, absorbing ecological shocks and fostering peaceful co-existence.

- **Buffer Zone Functions:** Reduces edge effects on core zones, accommodates regulated eco-tourism, and offers sustainable livelihood options to peripheral communities.
- **Captive Wildlife Care:** Health rejuvenation camps for forest service elephants enhance operational efficiency for patrolling inaccessible core terrains.
- **Conflict Mitigation:** Engaging local populations during events in buffer zones builds public empathy and lowers human-elephant conflict instances.
- **Ecological Corridors:** Effective buffer management ensures structural connectivity for migratory wildlife like elephant herds.

Strengthening Eco-Development Committees and promoting participatory management are vital for sustaining long-term biodiversity conservation.

Keywords to use: Buffer Zone Management, Captive Elephant Welfare, Human-Wildlife Conflict, Eco-Development Committees, Project Elephant

Newspaper words

advocated	समर्थन किया	publicly recommended or supported a policy or cause
multilateral	बहुपक्षीय	involving three or more nations or groups
attribution	उत्तरदायित्व निर्धारण	the action of identifying the cause or responsible party for an event
accountability	जवाबदेही	the fact of being responsible for one's decisions or actions
rejuvenation	कायाकल्प	the process of restoring health, vitality, or energy

1. Supreme Court to hear challenge against fee on UPI merchant payments

The Supreme Court will hear a Public Interest Litigation (PIL) challenging the Centre decision to levy a Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on specified Unified Payments Interface (UPI) transactions over 2,000 rupees.

What happened	Supreme Court will hear a plea challenging the Centre decision to levy a 0.4 per cent Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on Unified Payments Interface (UPI) person to merchant transfers over 2,000 rupees.
Why UPSC cares	Understand the debate over Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on Unified Payments Interface (UPI) transactions, balancing digital adoption incentives with the financial sustainability of payment service providers.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: money and banking, digital infrastructure and monetary policy.
Chapter	Economy: Money and Banking

Read it for

- 1. Understand the concept of Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) and how payment infrastructure costs are shared.
- 2. Examine the regulatory framework governing digital payment systems like Unified Payments Interface (UPI).
- 3. Analyze the judicial review of executive economic decisions through Public Interest Litigation (PIL).

Key terms

Merchant Discount Rate (MDR)

A fee charged to merchants by payment service providers for processing transactions through digital channels.

Unified Payments Interface (UPI)

An instant real time payment system developed by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) to facilitate inter bank transactions.

Public Interest Litigation (PIL)

A legal action initiated in a court of law for the enforcement of public interest or general welfare.

Person-to-Merchant (P2M) Transactions

Financial transfers made by individual consumers to business merchants for purchasing goods or services.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding payment systems and fee structures in India:

1. Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) is a fee paid by retail customers directly to the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) when making digital purchases.
2. Unified Payments Interface (UPI) operates on a system where transactions are settled only during standard banking working hours.

- a. 1 only
- b. 2 only
- c. Both 1 and 2
- d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is incorrect because Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) is a charge paid by merchants to acquiring banks and payment service providers for accepting digital payments, not by retail customers to the central bank. Statement 2 is incorrect because UPI operates 24/7 in real time, allowing instantaneous money transfers round the clock regardless of standard banking working hours.

UPSC has asked this before UPSC Prelims 2018 · Q6

Which one of the following best describes the term "Merchant Discount Rate" sometimes seen in news ?

- a. The incentive given by a bank to a merchant for accepting payments through debit cards pertaining to that bank.
- b. The amount paid back by banks to their customers when they use debit cards for financial transactions for purchasing goods or services.
- c. The charge to a merchant by a bank for accepting payments from his customers through the bank's debit cards.
- d. The incentive given by the Government to merchants for promoting digital payments by their customers through Point of Sale (PoS) machines and debit cards.

Answer: (c) Official answer (UPSC answer key): C. Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) is the cost paid by a merchant to a bank for accepting payment from their customers through digital modes such as credit or debit cards. It compensates the bank, the card network, and the POS terminal provider for processing the transaction. Therefore, option (c) correctly describes this term.

Mains: how it could come

Discuss the economic implications of imposing a Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on digital transactions. How can policymakers balance financial inclusion with the sustainability of payment infrastructure? (150 words, 10 marks)

Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) is the fee levied on merchants for processing digital payment transactions, crucial for supporting financial ecosystem infrastructure.

- Economic rationale: Ensures revenue models for payment aggregators, acquiring banks, and technology providers, spurring digital infrastructure investment.
- Impact on merchants: Imposing MDR on transactions above a threshold prevents revenue loss for small traders while monetising large commercial transfers.
- Challenges to adoption: Charges may disincentivise small and medium businesses from accepting digital payments, pushing them back to cash.

Maintain a differential fee structure catering to thin-margin sectors alongside targeted government subsidies to sustain zero fee regimes for micro-merchants.

Keywords to use: Merchant Discount Rate, Unified Payments Interface, Digital Infrastructure, Financial Inclusion

GS2 · International Relations

2. Switzerland votes on proposal to enshrine stricter neutrality in constitution

Swiss voters decide on a proposal backed by the Swiss People's Party to limit unilateral sanctions and prohibit military alliance cooperation unless under direct attack.

What happened	Swiss voters evaluate a referendum backed by the Swiss People's Party to constitutionalize stricter neutrality, restricting non-UN sanctions and NATO cooperation.
Why UPSC cares	Analyze how global geopolitical polarization is forcing traditionally neutral nations to redefine their constitutional neutrality and its impact on international cooperation.
Syllabus	GS2 Polity and International Relations: Important international institutions, agencies and global security dynamics.
Chapter	Polity: Constitutions Around the World

Read it for

1. Constitutional provisions governing military neutrality and foreign alliance membership.
2. The distinction between United Nations sanctions and unilateral economic sanctions.
3. The operational impact of strict neutrality on participation in global defense cooperation.

Key terms

Permanent Neutrality

A sovereign legal status where a state commits to remain neutral in all future armed conflicts and refrains from joining military alliances.

Referendum

A direct vote in which an entire electorate is invited to accept or reject a particular political or constitutional proposal.

Unilateral Sanctions

Economic or political penalties imposed by an individual country against another state without authorisation from the United Nations Security Council (UNSC).

Collective Security

A system where a group of nations agrees that an attack on one member state is treated as an attack on all members.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding neutrality and international security:

1. Permanent neutrality is a legal status under international law where a state commits to remain neutral in all future armed conflicts.
2. Under Article 41 of the United Nations (UN) Charter, the United Nations Security Council (UNSC) has the authority to mandate economic sanctions binding on member states.
3. Neutral states retain the inherent right of individual self-defence under international law if subjected to an armed attack.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- a. 1 and 2 only
- b. 2 and 3 only
- c. 1 and 3 only
- d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (d) Statement 1 is correct: Permanent neutrality obligates a state to avoid taking part in external military conflicts and joining military alliances. Statement 2 is correct: Article 41 empowers the Security Council to order non-military measures including economic sanctions, which are binding on UN members. Statement 3 is correct: Article 51 of the UN Charter and customary international law explicitly protect the inherent right of all sovereign states, including neutral ones, to defend themselves against an armed attack.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the concept of permanent neutrality in international relations. How do domestic constitutional mandates of neutrality conflict with modern collective security mechanisms and economic sanctions regimes? (150 words, 10 marks)

Permanent neutrality is a recognised status under international law where a nation commits to abstain from participating in foreign wars and military alliances.

- Impact on military alliances: Restricts operational integration and joint defence arrangements with bodies like the North Atlantic Treaty Organisation (NATO).
- Restrictions on sanctions: Limits the sovereign capability to enforce non-United Nations Security Council (UNSC) economic sanctions during humanitarian or aggression crises.
- Role in global mediation: Provides a credible neutral platform for diplomatic negotiations, international arbitration, and peace facilitation.

Neutral states must continuously reconcile historic constitutional duties with contemporary global commitments under the United Nations (UN) legal framework.

Keywords to use: Permanent neutrality, Collective security, Unilateral sanctions, United Nations Security Council (UNSC), International law

GS3 · Environment

3. Maharashtra Governor calls for bamboo economy to drive sustainable growth

Maharashtra Governor Jishnu Dev Varma urged developing a bamboo-based economy in districts like Gadchiroli to foster green livelihoods and plastic alternatives.

What happened	Maharashtra Governor advocated for building a bamboo-based economy, replicating models from Tripura in districts like Gadchiroli.
Why UPSC cares	Evaluate the potential of a bamboo-based economy in achieving carbon neutrality, replacing single-use plastics, and generating sustainable rural employment.
Syllabus	GS3 Environment: Conservation, environmental pollution and degradation, environmental impact assessment.
Chapter	Environment: Cutting Emissions: Mitigation Paths

Read it for

1. Role of bio-based resources in climate change mitigation and plastic reduction.
2. Integration of tribal livelihoods with modern value chains and market access.
3. Policy interventions required to transition towards a circular economy.

Key terms

Circular Economy

An economic system aimed at eliminating waste and the continual use of resources through reuse, repair, remanufacturing and recycling.

Sustainable Development

Development that meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs.

Value Chain

The full range of activities required to bring a product from initial concept and production to final distribution and customer service.

Carbon Sequestration

The process of capturing and storing atmospheric carbon dioxide to mitigate climate change.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding bamboo and its environmental applications:

1. Bamboo belongs taxonomically to the grass family and grows rapidly, making it a sustainable renewable resource.
2. Bio-based alternatives made from bamboo help facilitate a transition towards a circular economy by replacing single-use plastics.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- a. 1 only
- b. 2 only
- c. Both 1 and 2
- d. Neither 1 nor 2

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct because bamboo belongs to the grass family (Poaceae) and is among the fastest-growing renewable plant resources. Statement 2 is correct because replacing synthetic, non-biodegradable materials with bio-based alternatives like bamboo supports sustainable production and consumption cycles.

Mains: how it could come

Discuss the potential of a bamboo-based economy in promoting sustainable rural development and mitigating climate change in India. (150 words, 10 marks)

A bamboo-based economy leverages high-yield renewable plant biomass to foster green manufacturing, rural employment, and ecological restoration.

- **Rural Livelihoods:** Provides income opportunities for tribal communities through harvesting, artisan craftsmanship, and modern processing hubs.
- **Climate Mitigation:** Bamboo acts as a rapid carbon sink, sequestering atmospheric carbon faster than many traditional hardwood species.
- **Circular Economy:** Replaces single-use plastics and timber, reducing pollution and industrial energy consumption in manufacturing.
- **Value Chain Integration:** Combining traditional artisanal skills with branding, digital marketing, and modern technology creates global export markets.

Strengthening rural infrastructure, technological upgradation, and market access can turn bamboo into a cornerstone of India's green growth strategy.

Keywords to use: Carbon Sequestration, Circular Economy, Tribal Livelihoods, Value Chain Development

Newspaper words

levy	कर या शुल्क लगाना	to officially impose a tax, fee, or fine
enshrine	सुरक्षित करना या संजोना	to preserve or protect a right, law, or principle in a formal way
unilateral	एकपक्षीय	performed by or affecting only one person, group, or country
foster	बढ़ावा देना, प्रोत्साहित करना	to encourage the development or growth of something
mitigation	शमन या तीव्रता कम करना	the action of reducing the severity, seriousness, or painfulness of something

1. Five new heritage sites added to India's UNESCO tentative list

India's count on the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization tentative list reaches 78 with five new heritage sites and proposals.

What happened	Five new heritage sites and proposals, including the Bagh Caves, Chambal Valley temples, Udaigiri Caves, Ginnorgarh, and a transnational Satyagraha proposal with South Africa, have been added to the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization Tentative List, raising India's total to 78.
Why UPSC cares	Important for GS1 Art and Culture. Understanding the criteria for United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) World Heritage sites is crucial for Mains.
Syllabus	GS1 Indian Heritage and Culture: Salient aspects of Art Forms, Literature and Architecture from ancient to modern times.
Chapter	History: India Before Colonial Takeover

Read it for

1. Understand the difference between the tentative list and the final World Heritage List.
2. Examine the historical and architectural significance of Bagh Caves and Udaigiri Caves.
3. Note the procedure and criteria for nominating properties for global recognition.

Key terms

UNESCO Tentative List

An inventory of properties which a member state intends to consider for nomination to the World Heritage List. Submission of this list is a mandatory prerequisite for inscription.

Serial and Transnational Property

A nomination comprising two or more distinct component parts sharing historical, thematic, or geographical links, sometimes spanning across international borders.

Gupta-era Udaigiri Caves

Rock-cut cave sanctuaries near Vidisha, Madhya Pradesh, containing some of the oldest surviving Hindu sculptures and inscriptions from the Gupta Empire period.

Bagh Cave Paintings

A group of nine rock-cut monuments located in Madhya Pradesh, famous for mural paintings executed on a mud plaster similar to the Ajanta paintings.

Mains: how it could come

Discuss the significance of expanding India's footprint on the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization tentative heritage list. How does such recognition aid in the preservation of civilisational heritage and boost cultural diplomacy? (150 words, 10 marks)

Inclusion in the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization tentative list acts as a crucial stepping stone for international recognition and domestic preservation of diverse heritage assets.

- Showcases extraordinary diversity: Highlighting regional art forms like Bagh cave paintings and tribal legacies brings marginalized histories to the global fore.
- Conservation standards: Encourages rigorous documentation, legal protection, and scientific management protocols aligned with global benchmarks.
- Cultural diplomacy: Transnational nominations, such as the Sites of Satyagraha with South Africa, foster international solidarity and shared historical narratives.
- Economic impetus: Boosts sustainable cultural tourism, generating local employment and funding for site maintenance.

India must fast-track the conversion of tentative listings into permanent inscriptions by strengthening local administrative capacity and community involvement.

Keywords to use: Tentative List, Civilisational Heritage, Serial Nomination, Cultural Diplomacy, Udaigiri Caves

GS2 · International Relations

2. India and Saudi Arabia review strategic ties, investment and digital links

India and Saudi Arabia reviewed defence, trade and technology cooperation while finalising a bilateral investment treaty.

What happened	India and Saudi Arabia reviewed bilateral cooperation in trade, defence and energy, and finalized a Bilateral Investment Treaty.
Why UPSC cares	Important for General Studies (GS) 2 International Relations. Analyzing India's strategic partnerships in West Asia, particularly with Saudi Arabia, is a recurring theme in Mains bilateral relations questions.
Syllabus	GS2: Bilateral, regional and global groupings involving India and/or affecting India's interests.
Chapter	Economy: International Financial Institutions

Read it for

1. Understand the strategic and economic pillars of bilateral ties between India and West Asian nations.
2. Examine the legal and economic significance of Bilateral Investment Treaties in cross-border capital flows.
3. Analyze the role of multilateral financial institutions like the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank in regional development.

Key terms

Bilateral Investment Treaty

An agreement between two countries to promote and protect foreign investments made by investors of each country in the territory of the other.

Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank

A multilateral development bank that aims to support the building of infrastructure in the Asia-Pacific region and beyond.

Unified Payments Interface

An instant real-time payment system developed by the National Payments Corporation of India to facilitate inter-bank transactions.

GIFT International Financial Services Centre

India's first operational smart city and international financial services centre designed to bring back offshore financial transactions to India.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding Bilateral Investment Treaties (BITs):

- 1. BITs establish legally binding rights and obligations concerning foreign direct investments between two countries.**
- 2. They typically include provisions for investor-state dispute settlement mechanisms.**
- 3. India's model BIT relies primarily on international arbitration without requiring the exhaustion of local remedies first.**

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- a. 1 only
- b. 1 and 2 only
- c. 2 and 3 only
- d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (b) Statement 1 is correct because BITs set reciprocal standards for the treatment and protection of foreign investments. Statement 2 is correct as these treaties provide mechanisms to resolve disputes between investors and host states. Statement 3 is incorrect because India's model BIT requires investors to exhaust local judicial remedies for at least five years before initiating international arbitration.

Mains: how it could come

Analyze the significance of deepening economic and strategic ties between India and West Asian nations, with special reference to Saudi Arabia. (150 words, 10 marks)

India's relations with West Asia have evolved from a buyer-seller energy dynamic into a comprehensive strategic partnership encompassing trade, investment, and security.

- **Energy Security and Transition:** Saudi Arabia remains a vital supplier of crude oil while partnering in renewable energy and green hydrogen initiatives.
- **Trade and Investment:** Conclusion of bilateral investment frameworks and sovereign wealth fund investments in sectors like infrastructure and technology boost economic ties.
- **Diaspora and Remittances:** Millions of Indian expatriates in West Asia contribute significantly to foreign exchange reserves and human capital ties.
- **Security Cooperation:** Joint exercises, counter-terrorism intelligence sharing, and maritime security in the Indian Ocean region strengthen mutual trust.

Institutionalizing bilateral mechanisms, fast-tracking free trade agreements, and expanding digital financial integration will further consolidate this partnership.

Keywords to use: Strategic Partnership, Energy Security, Bilateral Investment Treaty, Sovereign Wealth Fund, Diaspora

GS3 · Environment and Conservation

3. India showcases forest and landscape restoration initiatives at COFO 28 in Rome

India highlighted its national efforts in forest and landscape restoration during the Committee on Forestry session held in Rome.

What happened	India showcased its forest and landscape restoration initiatives at the twenty-eighth session of the Committee on Forestry in Rome.
Why UPSC cares	Important for General Studies (GS) 3 Environment. Forest restoration initiatives and international platforms like the Committee on Forestry (COFO) are vital for addressing land degradation.
Syllabus	GS3 Environment: Conservation, environmental pollution and degradation
Chapter	Environment: Global Environmental Agreements

Read it for

1. Understand the mandate and role of the Food and Agriculture Organization Committee on Forestry.
2. Examine India's major policy initiatives and targets for land degradation neutrality and afforestation.
3. Analyze the importance of forest and landscape restoration in meeting global climate and biodiversity goals.

Key terms

Committee on Forestry

The Food and Agriculture Organization Committee on Forestry is the highest FAO forestry statutory body, reviewing global forestry issues and advising on policy and technical matters.

Forest and Landscape Restoration

A planned process that aims to regain ecological integrity and enhance human well-being in deforested or degraded forest landscapes.

Land Degradation Neutrality

A state whereby the amount and quality of land resources necessary to support ecosystem functions remain stable or increase.

Food and Agriculture Organization

A specialized agency of the United Nations that leads international efforts to defeat hunger and improve nutrition and agriculture.

Mains: how it could come

Discuss the significance of forest and landscape restoration in addressing climate change and land degradation in India. Examine the challenges involved in implementing these initiatives at the grassroots level. (150 words, 10 marks)

Forest and landscape restoration is a vital strategy for mitigating climate change, reversing land degradation, and enhancing rural livelihoods in India.

- Restores degraded ecosystems, improving carbon sequestration and biodiversity corridors.
- Supports international commitments like Land Degradation Neutrality and Nationally Determined Contributions.
- Engages local communities through Joint Forest Management to ensure sustainable resource use.
- Faces challenges such as competing land use pressures, funding constraints, and invasive species proliferation.

Integrating traditional ecological knowledge with scientific monitoring and empowering local institutions will ensure long-term success of restoration drives.

Keywords to use: Forest Restoration, Land Degradation Neutrality, Carbon Sequestration, Joint Forest Management, Biodiversity Conservation

Newspaper words

transnational	अंतरराष्ट्रीय	extending across national boundaries
significance	महत्व	the importance or meaning of something
bilateral	द्विपक्षीय	involving two countries
diaspora	प्रवासी समुदाय	people scattered from their homeland to other countries
mandate	अधिकार क्षेत्र या आदेश	an official order or commission to do something

1. India remains fastest growing major economy with 7.9 percent average growth

Addressing an economic forum, Shaktikanta Das stated that India recorded 7.9 percent average real GDP growth between 2021-22 and 2025-26.

What happened	Principal Secretary-2 to Prime Minister (PM) Narendra Modi, Shaktikanta Das, highlighted that India recorded an average annual real Gross Domestic Product (GDP) growth of 7.9 percent from 2021-22 to 2025-26, alongside a 7.8 percent GDP growth in the first quarter of the current financial year.
Why UPSC cares	India's robust Gross Domestic Product (GDP) growth rate of 7.9 percent highlights economic resilience, which is crucial for analyzing growth sustainability and structural reforms in Mains.
Syllabus	GS3 Indian Economy: growth, development, and macro-economic stability.
Chapter	Economy: Basics of Macroeconomics

Read it for

- 1. Understand the difference between real and nominal Gross Domestic Product (GDP) growth metrics.
- 2. Analyze the expanding economic footprint of the Global South and emerging economies in global output.
- 3. Examine key principles guiding macro-economic and financial stability during global uncertainties.

Key terms

Real GDP Growth

The rate at which a nation's Gross Domestic Product (GDP) expands after adjusting for inflation, using base year constant prices.

Global South

A broad term used to describe developing, low-income, or emerging market nations predominantly located in Asia, Africa, and Latin America.

Emerging Market Economies

Developing economies experiencing rapid industrialization, institutional modernization, and high economic growth rates relative to mature markets.

Structural Reforms

Policy changes aimed at improving the fundamental framework of an economy, such as labor rules, trade regulations, and tax systems.

Increase in absolute and per capita real GNP do not connote a higher level of economic development, if

- a. industrial output fails to keep pace with agricultural output.
- b. agricultural output fails to keep pace with industrial output.
- c. poverty and unemployment increase.
- d. imports grow faster than exports.

Answer: (c) Official answer (UPSC answer key): C. Economic development implies qualitative improvements along with quantitative growth. If absolute and per capita real GNP increases, but poverty and unemployment also increase, the benefits of growth are not trickling down to the masses. Thus, such a scenario does not connote a higher level of economic development.

Mains: how it could come

Despite severe geopolitical fragmentation and global trade bottlenecks, India has sustained high real GDP growth rates. Examine the underlying factors driving this resilience and discuss the structural reforms needed to convert this growth into inclusive long-term development. (150 words, 10 marks)

India has sustained robust growth driven by macro-economic stability, domestic market demand, and targeted public capital expenditure.

- Drivers of Growth: Large-scale public infrastructure creation, financial sector deleveraging, digital public infrastructure, and structural reforms.
- Global South Synergy: Expanding trade ties, increasing Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) inflows, and rising share in intermediate goods production.
- Key Challenges: High global interest rates, trade protectionism, volatile commodity prices, and structural employment deficits.
- Required Interventions: Manufacturing push through schemes like Production Linked Incentive (PLI), labor market modernization, and agricultural efficiency enhancement.

Ensuring inclusive expansion requires balancing capital-intensive infrastructure with quality education, healthcare, and skill development for youth.

Keywords to use: Real GDP Growth, Macroeconomic Stability, Global South, Structural Reforms, Capital Expenditure

GS3 · Science and Technology

2. Supreme Court flags high markups on cancer drugs by private hospitals

The Supreme Court has asked the Centre to examine allegations of corporate hospitals forcing patients to buy medicines from their own pharmacies at high markups.

What happened

The Supreme Court expressed concern over high markups on cancer drugs by private hospitals and suggested a uniform 16 percent margin.

Why UPSC cares	The Supreme Court (SC) raising concerns over high profit margins on life-saving drugs links to healthcare affordability and regulatory policy, a key Mains topic under health and technology.
Syllabus	GS3 Science and Technology: Issues relating to intellectual property rights and health technology.
Chapter	Science & Tech: Viruses, Vaccines & Health Tech

Read it for

1. Regulatory mechanisms for drug pricing in India
2. Role of the Drugs (Prices Control) Order, 2013
3. Impact of high out of pocket expenditure on healthcare

Key terms

Drugs (Prices Control) Order (DPCO)

An order issued by the government under the Essential Commodities Act to regulate the prices of specified drugs and formulations.

National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA)

An independent regulator in India that sets and enforces price caps on essential medicines and monitors drug availability.

Scheduled Formulations

Medicines that are included in the National List of Essential Medicines and are subject to active price regulation by the government.

Non-scheduled Formulations

Medicines that are not part of the essential list but are monitored to ensure their annual price increase does not exceed ten percent.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the regulation of medicine prices in India:

1. The National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) regulates the prices of both scheduled and non-scheduled formulations.
2. The Drugs (Prices Control) Order is issued under the provisions of the Essential Commodities Act, 1955.
3. Non-scheduled formulations are allowed an unlimited annual price increase without any regulatory cap.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- a. 1 and 2 only
- b. 2 and 3 only
- c. 1 and 3 only
- d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (a) Statement 1 is correct because the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA) regulates the prices of scheduled drugs and monitors the prices of non-scheduled drugs. Statement 2 is correct because the Drugs (Prices Control) Order is issued under the Essential Commodities Act, 1955. Statement 3 is incorrect because the annual price increase for non-scheduled formulations is capped at ten percent under the current regulations.

Mains: how it could come

Examine the regulatory challenges in controlling the prices of non-scheduled medicines and medical devices in India. Suggest measures to reduce out-of-pocket expenditure on healthcare. (150 words, 10 marks)

High out-of-pocket expenditure on healthcare, largely driven by medicine and diagnostic costs, is a major factor pushing families into poverty in India.

- The Drugs (Prices Control) Order primarily regulates scheduled formulations, leaving a vast market of non-scheduled drugs with limited oversight.
- Private hospitals often impose steep markups on medicines and consumables, bypassing standard trade margins.
- There is a lack of strict enforcement regarding generic prescriptions, leading to patients purchasing expensive branded alternatives.

Implementing a rational cap on trade margins for all medical supplies and strengthening the enforcement of generic medicine prescriptions can significantly lower healthcare costs.

Keywords to use: National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority, Out-of-pocket expenditure, Drugs Prices Control Order, Trade margin rationalisation

GS2 · International Relations

3. Border resolution improves India-China ties, says foreign minister

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar addressed bilateral ties with China, trade talks with the United States, and energy vulnerabilities facing the Global South.

What happened	External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar stated in New York that India-China relations improved following the resolution of the border standoff, while highlighting trade complexities with the United States and energy distress in the Global South.
Why UPSC cares	The resolution of the border standoff and subsequent improvement in bilateral relations, as highlighted by the External Affairs Minister (EAM), are vital for regional security under International Relations.
Syllabus	GS2: Bilateral, regional and global groupings and agreements involving India and/or affecting India's interests.
Chapter	Polity: India's External Relations

Read it for

1. Interdependence between border peace and bilateral normalisation with China.
2. Structural economic differences impacting India-United States trade negotiations.
3. Impact of geopolitical conflicts on energy security across the Global South.

Key terms

Border Standoff

A situation where military forces of two countries confront each other along an unsettled boundary without engaging in outright war.

Global South

A collective term for developing and emerging economies, primarily located in Africa, Latin America, and Asia, facing shared developmental challenges.

Tariff

A tax or custom duty imposed by a government on imported goods to protect domestic industries or raise fiscal revenue.

Strategic Autonomy

The foreign policy doctrine of pursuing national interests and making sovereign decisions without succumbing to external pressure or formal alliances.

Prelims: how it could come

Consider the following statements regarding the Line of Actual Control (LAC) and India-China border agreements:

- 1. The 1993 Agreement on the Maintenance of Peace and Tranquility along the LAC formally committed both nations to respect the status quo.**
- 2. The entire length of the Line of Actual Control is mutually demarcated on ground and agreed upon on standard maps.**
- 3. The Special Representatives mechanism was established to find an agreed framework for a boundary settlement.**

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- a. 1 and 2 only
- b. 2 and 3 only
- c. 1 and 3 only
- d. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: (c) Statement 1 is correct: The 1993 Border Peace and Tranquility Agreement was a landmark accord binding both sides to respect the Line of Actual Control. Statement 2 is incorrect: The LAC is not mutually demarcated on the ground, nor are there mutually agreed maps across its entire length, which leads to differing perceptions and friction. Statement 3 is correct: The Special Representatives (SR) mechanism was set up in 2003 to provide a political perspective to resolving the boundary issue.

Mains: how it could come

Border tranquility remains the prerequisite for normalisation of India-China ties, even as India deepens engagement with the West. Discuss the challenges in managing this strategic equilibrium. (150 words, 10 marks)

India pursues strategic autonomy by calibrating ties with China while simultaneously strengthening its comprehensive global strategic partnership with Western nations.

- **Border dynamics:** Unsettled boundaries and infrastructure build-up along the Line of Actual Control generate persistent mistrust, demanding that peace precede broad-based economic cooperation.
- **Trade and economic dependencies:** Managing trade imbalances with China while addressing tariff and market-access concerns with Western partners like the United States protects domestic smallholder livelihoods.
- **Global South advocacy:** Rising energy prices caused by Eurasian and West Asian conflicts require independent foreign policy choices, such as discounted crude purchases, which often test Western ties.
- **Multilateral hedging:** Active engagement in both Western-oriented forums like the Quad and Eurasian platforms like BRICS safeguards India's continental and maritime security interests.

India must continue enhancing its border infrastructure and domestic industrial capacities while relying on principled diplomacy to preserve its sovereign strategic choices.

Keywords to use: Strategic autonomy, Line of Actual Control (LAC), Multi-alignment, Economic asymmetry, Global South energy security

Newspaper words

uncertainties	अनिश्चितताएं	Situations that are unknown, unpredictable, or lacking certainty
economic footprint	आर्थिक प्रभाव	The total impact or presence of an economy in the world
markups	लाभ मार्जिन	Increases in price added to the cost to make a profit
out of pocket expenditure	जेब से होने वाला खर्च	Direct spending of personal money not covered by insurance
standoff	गतिरोध	A deadlock or stalemate in a dispute